

Project Magazine

VOL 3

Touching
Lives,
Transforming
Households,
Impacting
communities.

Putting a smile on a Face!

LEARNING FOR A BRIGHTER FUTURE

Accelerated Basic Education Programme
(ABEP) for out-of-school children in
Sokoto State. Implemented by Life
Helpers Initiative (LHI), funded by the
European Union through UNICEF



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Inside This Issue

This edition features a comprehensive overview of the EU-UNICEF ABEP program implemented by Life Helpers Initiative in Sokoto State. It highlights key milestones achieved during the first quarter of implementation, from February to May 2026.

Human-Angle Stories

Four inspiring stories of children and community members whose lives have been transformed through access to education.

Official Launch

A dedicated section on the official launch of learning delivery and the partnership that makes ABEP possible.

Community Engagement

Deep dive into centre-based management committees and how communities are driving education forward.

Crisis Modifier & Radio

Update on the crisis modifier and radio learning preparedness for emergency response.

Data Snapshot

Detailed data comparing targets against actual achievements with visual charts and progress bars.

Challenges & Way Forward

A candid look at challenges encountered and proposed solutions for sustainable programme delivery.

The magazine showcases four inspiring human-angle stories of children and community members whose lives have been transformed through access to education. It also features a dedicated section on the official launch of learning delivery and the partnership that makes ABEP possible.

Readers will also find a deep dive into community engagement through Centre-Based Management Committees, an update on the crisis modifier and radio learning preparedness, and a detailed data snapshot comparing targets against actual achievements. The issue concludes with a candid look at the challenges we faced during the reporting period and the way forward to ensure sustainable program delivery.





“About the Programme”

The Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) is a strategic educational intervention designed to expand access to quality learning opportunities for out-of-school and over-aged children who have been excluded from formal education. Implemented by Life Helpers Initiative (LHI) with funding from the European Union through UNICEF, the program supports children in acquiring foundational literacy, numeracy, and life skills while creating pathways for their successful transition into the formal education system.

Operating across six local government areas of Sokoto State- Goronyo, Rabah, Tambuwal, Tangaza, Tureta, and Wurno the programme responds to persistent barriers to education by providing safe, inclusive, and learner-centred environments where vulnerable children can learn, grow, and realise their potential.

Since its inception, ABEP has delivered measurable results that reflect the power of partnership and community engagement. During the reporting period, 3,255 out-of-school children were enrolled in learning centres across the six LGAs, providing them with renewed opportunities to access education and build brighter futures. To ensure the delivery of quality learning, 105 facilitators were recruited, trained, and deployed across 35 operational learning centers, strengthening the programme’s capacity to reach children in underserved communities.

Community ownership remains central to the programme's approach. Through targeted capacity-strengthening initiatives, 164 members of Community-Based Management Committees (CBMCs) were trained to support learner enrollment, retention, safeguarding, and community mobilisation. This investment in local leadership has enhanced accountability, strengthened community participation, and contributed to the sustainability of education outcomes.

The program continues to demonstrate how coordinated action among communities, government institutions, development partners, and local stakeholders can improve access to education, promote inclusion, and create lasting opportunities for children who might otherwise be left behind.



MOBILIZING STAKEHOLDERS FOR SUCCESS

The successful implementation of the Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) was built on a foundation of strong partnerships, strategic collaboration, and community engagement. Recognising that sustainable education outcomes require collective ownership, Life Helpers Initiative (LHI), in collaboration with government institutions and development partners, undertook extensive advocacy and coordination efforts before program rollout.

Engagements were conducted with key stakeholders at both state and local levels, including the Ministry of Education, the State Agency for Mass Education (SAME), the Sokoto State Universal Basic Education Board (SUBEB), Local Government Authorities, traditional and religious leaders, and Community-Based Management Committees (CBMCs). These consultations served as an important platform for aligning priorities, clarifying roles and responsibilities, and strengthening coordination mechanisms among all actors involved in programme delivery.

Through these engagements, stakeholders demonstrated strong commitment to supporting the programme and ensuring its successful implementation across the target communities. The consultations fostered trust, strengthened local ownership, and created an enabling environment for the delivery of quality education services to out-of-school children.



OFFICIAL LAUNCH OF THE PROJECT

The Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) was officially launched on 21st April 2026 at the Makarantar Malam Bala Liman Salah Centre in Tambuwal LGA, Sokoto State. The ceremony marked a significant milestone in the collective effort to address the out-of-school children crisis and expand access to quality basic education across the state.

The event was led by the Permanent Secretary of the Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education, representing the Honourable Commissioner. It brought together government officials, education stakeholders, community leaders, facilitators, learners, development partners, and media representatives, demonstrating a shared commitment to tackling the education crisis.

In his address, the Permanent Secretary commended the European Union and UNICEF for their continued support and praised the Life Helpers Initiative for its technical support and successful distribution of teaching and learning materials. He emphasised that ABEP provides a second chance for thousands of children denied access to education due to poverty, displacement, or cultural barriers.



The launch symbolized a shared commitment to addressing the out-of-school children crisis and expanding access to quality education.

The UNICEF Desk Officer highlighted the importance of the partnership, noting that ABEP is about building a future for Sokoto State. Community leaders expressed gratitude and pledged full support, noting that parents are eager to enroll their children.

The flag-off marked the official start of learning delivery across the 35 ABEP centers. The launch also featured a symbolic distribution of learning materials to the first cohort of learners, signaling the beginning of their educational journey.



MESSAGE FROM LHI

Across Sokoto State, thousands of children remain out of school due to poverty, displacement, and limited access to quality education. Through the Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP), Life Helpers Initiative (LHI), with support from the European Union through UNICEF and partnership from SEMA, is creating opportunities for these children to learn, grow, and transition into formal education.

This quarter marked a significant milestone as learning activities commenced across six Local Government Areas. Through strong collaboration with government institutions, community leaders, facilitators, and parents, we have expanded access to education for some of the most vulnerable children.

The progress achieved demonstrates what is possible when communities and development partners work together toward a common goal: ensuring that every child has the opportunity to learn.

**“EDUCATION
CANNOT WAIT”**

**ISA USMAN
PROJECT LEAD**



OPENING THE DOORS OF LEARNING

At the heart of the Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) is a commitment to ensuring that every child has the opportunity to learn, thrive, and realise their full potential. During the reporting period, the programme achieved a major milestone with the enrolment of 3,255 out-of-school children across 35 learning centres in six Local Government Areas of Sokoto State.

For many of these learners, access to education had been interrupted or denied due to a range of socio-economic and structural challenges, including poverty, mobility, displacement, and cultural barriers. Through targeted community mobilisation and inclusive enrollment efforts, the programme has helped reconnect thousands of children with learning opportunities, giving them a renewed sense of purpose and hope for the future.

Central to this achievement is the creation of safe, inclusive, and child-friendly learning environments where learners can develop foundational skills and build confidence. The programme supports children through well-equipped learning centers staffed by trained facilitators who employ learner-centred teaching approaches tailored to the needs of out-of-school and over-aged learners. In addition, learners benefit from access to essential learning materials, strong community support systems, and robust safeguarding measures designed to promote their well-being and protection.

Beyond improving access to education, ABEP is helping to transform lives by creating pathways for learners to transition into formal schooling and pursue greater opportunities for personal and social development. For thousands of children across Sokoto State, the programme represents far more than a return to the classroom it offers a second chance to learn, grow, and build a brighter future.





From Wheelbarrow to Classroom

With funding from the EU Civil Protection & Humanitarian Aid in partnership with UNICEF, MOBSE, SAME, and SUBEB, and with support from LHI, Nasiru Umar is 18 years old, the fourth of six children from Gaulaumba in Kebbi State, Nigeria. His father, a farmer, passed away when Nasiru was still young. After the loss, his mother, once a housewife, struggled to provide for the family by raising goats and sheep. His elder sister married without ever attending school, while his siblings followed their father's path into farming.

Determined to support his family, Nasiru dropped out of primary school. He pushed wheelbarrows in the market, carrying heavy loads for customers and bringing the money home. "We ate rice only occasionally," he recalls, as most of their earnings went to survival and his sister's marriage expenses. Three years ago, Nasiru moved from Kebbi to Sokoto State..

His uncle, wanting him to have an education as the first son of the house, brought him to Mohammed Kofar Gwandu Arabic School in Wamakko Local Government Area. There, Nasiru studies under a Malam, often sleeping in the classroom or at the teacher's house. After the Islamic school, he returns to the market to push wheelbarrows, earning money for food.

One day, his Malam heard about the EU and UNICEF's Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) and registered Nasiru. That moment gave him hope. "Ilmi shi ne makamin rayuwa" (Education is the weapon of life), he says, proud to be learning again.

Today, Nasiru balances study and work, carrying both loads and dreams. His journey shows that with opportunity, even children burdened by hardship can build resilience and a brighter future.

A Bag, A Dream

Saudatu Aliyu is 14 years old, the second of seven children in a family from Worno Local Government Area, Sokoto State, Nigeria. Her father is a local businessman, and until recently, only her eldest sibling had ever attended school. Saudatu spent her days helping at the market, learning a few words from her brother, and dreaming of a different future.

When she heard of the opportunity to attend a nonformal learning center through UNICEF and local partners, she begged her father to let her go. “Baba, it is free,” she pleaded, determined to pursue her dream of becoming a doctor. Inspired by the doctors she saw healing sick children, Saudatu wanted to learn so she could help others. The first days were difficult.

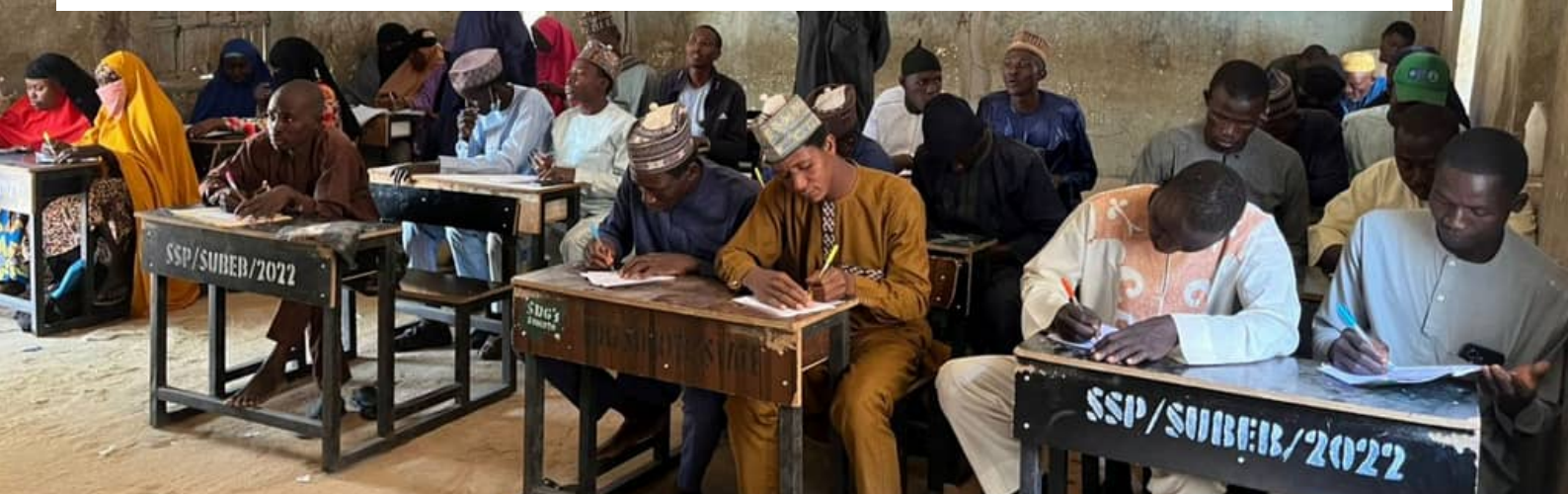
She struggled with reading and writing, but her determination never wavered. She cherished her school bag, a symbol of belonging, and admired her teacher, who encouraged her progress. “Ilmi da karatu yana daɗi” (Education is sweet), she says proudly, happy to be the second child in her family to receive what she calls “ilimin boko na Turawa” (Western education).

Thanks to EU Civil Protection & Humanitarian Aid, UNICEF, and partners like LHI, Saudatu now walks to school with her friends, carrying her bag and her dream. With funding from the EU Civil Protection & Humanitarian Aid and in partnership with UNICEF, MOBSE, SAME, SUBEB, and other stakeholders, this opportunity was made possible. Her story is a reminder that when girls are given the chance to learn, they carry the future in their hands.

Saudatu believes girls should not be limited to selling foodstuffs or staying at home. She calls on parents to send their daughters to school so they too can learn, grow, and contribute to their communities. As she says in Hausa, “Ilmi shi ne hasken rayuwa” (Education is the light of life).



Empowering 105 Facilitators to Deliver Quality Learning



Quality education begins with well-prepared and motivated educators. Recognising the critical role facilitators play in shaping learning outcomes, the Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) invested significantly in building the capacity of individuals responsible for delivering learning across the programme's target communities.

A highly competitive recruitment programme attracted more than 680 applicants from across Sokoto State. Following a rigorous selection process, 105 qualified facilitators were recruited and deployed to support teaching and learning activities across the six participating Local Government Areas. The recruitment exercise ensured that learners would benefit from dedicated educators equipped with the skills and commitment needed to support accelerated learning.

To prepare facilitators for effective program delivery, a comprehensive three-day capacity-strengthening workshop was conducted. The training focused on key areas essential for quality learning delivery, including the ABEP curriculum, learner-centred teaching methodologies, classroom management techniques, child safeguarding principles, learner assessment approaches, and the use of digital enrollment and reporting systems. Through interactive sessions, practical exercises, and collaborative learning activities, facilitators strengthened their ability to create inclusive and engaging learning environments that respond to the diverse needs of learners.

The investment in facilitator development yielded measurable results. Knowledge assessments conducted before and after the training demonstrated a significant improvement in participants' understanding of programme content and delivery approaches, with average scores increasing from 35 percent during the pre-training assessment to 65 percent following the workshop. These gains reflect enhanced readiness among facilitators to support learners effectively and deliver quality education services.

Today, the 105 trained facilitators serve as frontline agents of change within their communities, helping out-of-school children regain confidence, develop foundational literacy and numeracy skills, and build pathways toward continued learning and future opportunities. Their dedication and commitment remain central to the programme's mission of ensuring that every child has access to quality education and the opportunity to thrive.



Strengthening Community Ownership

Sustainable education outcomes are best achieved when communities play an active role in supporting and shaping the learning journey of their children. Recognising this, the Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) places community ownership at the centre of its implementation approach, empowering local structures to become champions of education and advocates for learner success.



A key component of this effort was the capacity strengthening of 164 members of Community Based Management Committees (CBMCs) across the programme's target communities. Through a series of training sessions, committee members enhanced their knowledge and skills in community mobilisation, behaviour change communication, child protection, learner retention, and local advocacy. These trainings equipped participants with practical tools to support enrolment drives, address barriers to education, and promote the importance of continuous learning within their communities.

The programme also facilitated regular review and coordination meetings, providing a platform for community leaders and stakeholders to assess progress, identify challenges, and develop locally driven solutions.



As a result, communities are increasingly taking ownership of educational outcomes and demonstrating a stronger commitment to ensuring that children remain engaged in learning. The active participation of local leaders, parents, and community structures has contributed significantly to creating an enabling environment where education is valued, supported, and sustained.

By investing in community leadership and fostering collective responsibility, ABEP is helping to build resilient local systems that will continue to support children's education long after the programme concludes. This growing sense of ownership not only strengthens programme impact but also lays the foundation for lasting and sustainable change.

The Impact Beyond the Classroom

For Alhaji Rufai Maccido Salah, the village head of Dogon Daji in Tambuwal LGA, the impact of the Accelerated Basic Education Programme (ABEP) goes far beyond enrollment numbers; it is transforming the mindset of an entire community.

“When this programme started, we were hopeful, but today we are witnessing something truly remarkable,” he said. “The children are excited about learning, eager to attend classes, and proud to be part of the programme. What touches me most is that even children who did not receive school bags still come to class every day because they genuinely want to learn.”



According to him, the positive changes have inspired many older children who were previously out of school to seek enrollment opportunities. Parents are also becoming stronger advocates for education and are now requesting adult learning programmes after seeing the transformation among their children.

“I regularly visit the centres and can see the difference for myself,” he added. “What may appear small to others has brought significant change to our community. We are grateful to the European Union, UNICEF, Life Helpers Initiative, and the Sokoto State Government for giving our children hope, confidence, and a brighter future.”



Ready to Respond: Keeping Education Alive in Emergencies

The ABEP programme includes a Crisis Modifier, which is a rapid-response mechanism designed to ensure continued learning during humanitarian shocks such as displacement, violent crises, or natural disasters. During this reporting period, no emergencies occurred in the target communities, so the team focused entirely on preparedness.

Preparedness activities included the identification of 315 radio facilitators who will be deployed when a crisis triggers the modifier. A structured three day training curriculum for interactive radio learning was designed, covering child protection, inclusive education principles, and effective radio-based instruction. Monthly review meetings have been planned to maintain operational readiness and ensure facilitators remain engaged and prepared.

The Crisis Modifier is designed to complement in-person instruction by providing remote learning options when physical attendance is impossible due to security concerns or displacement. It ensures that children can continue their education even in the most challenging circumstances.

SYSTEM READY - NO CRISIS TRIGGERED

Key Preparedness Highlights

315

Facilitators
Identified

3-Day

Training Curriculum
Designed

Monthly

Review Meetings
Planned

"We are not waiting for a crisis to act. Our systems are ready to switch on the moment children need remote learning."

Project Lead, LHI

Q1 Performance at a Glance

Table 1: Q1 Performance Summary

Indicator	Annual Target	Q1 Target	Q1 Achievement (M/F)	Total	% Achieved
Facilitators and LGA Officers Trained	105	105	79M / 26F	105	100%
CBMC Members Trained	164	164	124M / 40F	164	100%
Out-of-School Children Enrolled	3,083	3,083	1,410M / 1,845F	3,255	105.6%
Children with Disabilities Enrolled	--	--	16M / 28F	44	--
Children Who Received TLMs	3,083	3,083	1,410M / 1,845F	3,255	105.6%
Facilitators Trained - Crisis Modifier	315	0	0M / 0F	0	0%*
Learners Reached - Emergency Radio	5,819	0	0M / 0F	0	0%*
Children Mainstreamed into Formal Schools	924	0	0M / 0F	0	0%*

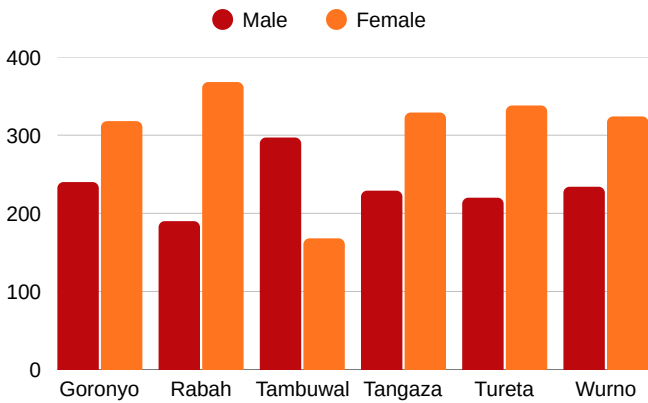
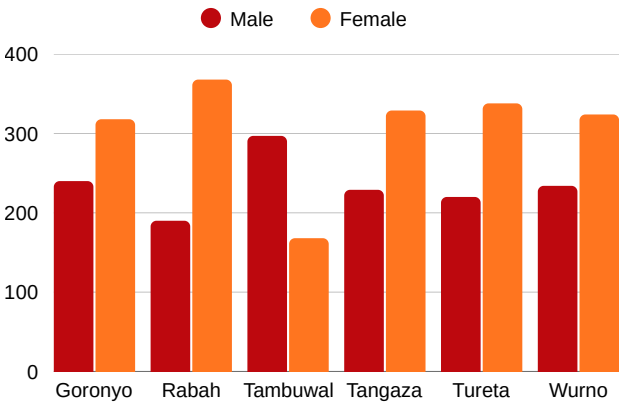
Note: The Crisis Modifier was not activated due to the absence of an emergency trigger. The system remains fully ready for deployment when needed.

Table 2: Learner Enrolment Breakdown by LGA

LGA	Male	Female	Total
Goronyo	240	318	558
Rabah	190	368	558
Tambuwal	297	168	465
Tangaza	229	329	558
Tureta	220	338	558
Wurno	234	324	558
Total	1,410	1,845	3,255

Table 3: Facilitator Breakdown by LGA

LGA	Male	Female	Total
Goronyo	12	6	18
Rabah	15	3	18
Tambuwal	13	2	15
Tangaza	13	5	18
Tureta	17	1	18
Wurno	9	9	18
Total	79	26	105



Programme Output Status

- Output 1: Quality learning through ABEP delivery
- Output 2: Emergency radio learning (Crisis Modifier)
- Output 3: Equitable access to quality education

On Track

Pending Activation

On Track

Strengthening

Accountability



Joint Supervision

A particularly impactful aspect of the quality assurance framework was the quarterly joint supportive supervision visits conducted in collaboration with government agencies and community representatives. These supervision visits brought together key stakeholders, including the Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education, the State Agency for Mass Education, SUBEB, UNICEF Desk Officers, LGA Scheme Organisers, and Community-Based Management Committees.

The involvement of multiple stakeholders in these supervision visits reinforced a culture of shared responsibility and collective accountability. Government agencies provided technical oversight and policy alignment, while community representatives ensured that local perspectives and concerns were heard and addressed. This multi-stakeholder approach not only strengthened programme quality but also built trust and ownership among all partners involved.



Continuous Learning and Improvement

Beyond formal supervision visits, the programme maintained a culture of continuous learning and improvement through regular data collection, analysis, and reflection. Facilitators were encouraged to document their experiences, share best practices, and learn from each other during bi-monthly review meetings. These meetings provided a platform for facilitators to discuss challenges, celebrate successes, and develop practical solutions to common problems.

Looking Ahead

Building on the successes of the first quarter, the programme will continue to strengthen its quality assurance and accountability mechanisms. Planned activities include expanded monitoring coverage, enhanced facilitator mentoring, and deeper engagement with CBMCs to sustain community ownership. The programme will also explore innovative approaches to data collection and analysis to improve real-time decision-making and ensure that every child receives the quality education they deserve.



Photo Speaks



Photo Speaks





OUR PARTNERS



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feedback@lhinigeria.org

Radio Nigeria
(Royal F.M 101.5, Sokoto State)
Every Tuesday: 11:00AM - 12:00PM (GMT)



WESPEAK (MUYI MAGANA)

WeSpeak, also known as Muiy Magana, is a weekly radio program implemented by Life Helpers Initiative in Sokoto State and aired weekly by Radio Nigeria (Royal F.M 101.5). The program cuts across all thematic areas, health, education, livelihood, agriculture, and gender equity.

The platform provides timely information, encourages dialogue, and creates space for questions, feedback, and external complaints. Community members share concerns, receive referrals, and learn about available services. Civil society organizations are also invited to use the platform to raise awareness about their work and promote collaboration.

The radio program has touched the lives of many people across Sokoto State by increasing awareness, promoting positive behavior change, and strengthening accountability.

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Be a leading non-governmental organisation working to maximise all opportunities to empower the marginalized people.

OUR VISION

A more Fulfilled Life for Everyone

    **LIFE HELPERS INITIATIVE**

